

The Galo's Silent Dawn

In the enchanted springs of Portugal, cobblestone towns sit among terracotta roofs, almond trees that blossom white as snow, and hills crowned with stars. Water is the magic here: every spring, fountain, and old stone well has its own quiet wonder. Enchanted maidens called the Mouras keep the springs sweet, a bright rooster crows only the truth, and a playful little goblin called the Trasgo tidies and teases when no one is looking. Here a hero wins not by being the strongest, but by being kind, asking the water gently, and never giving up on a friend. Even a big, fearsome-looking giant of the hills usually turns out to be lonelier than it is frightening.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.



Read aloud, slowly and warmly. Stop often to let the children answer. There are no wrong answers here, only new ideas to try.

Before you begin

It is very early in Barcelos, and something is wrong. The sky is grey. The market should be waking up, but everyone is upset. The bright rooster, the Galo de Barcelos, sits on his wall with his beak shut. He has lost his crow, so the morning will not begin.

Worse still, the shiny silver cup from the market has gone missing, and the townsfolk are blaming a tired traveller, just because he is a stranger. He looks very sad. You know he would never steal.

You pick up your bag. "Let us help," you say. "Let us find the truth."



What is your hero name? Which one or two magics do you choose: Bloom, Truth, Starlight, Riversong, or Birdsong?

Stop 1 The Silent Roost

You climb up to the Galo de Barcelos. Up close, he looks poorly and droopy. He opens his beak, but no sound comes out. He is sad because he cannot crow the truth and clear the traveller's name.

He needs cheering and a little kindness before his voice will come back.



How do you help the Galo feel better? Could you speak gently to him, sing with him, or fetch him a cool drink of spring water? What do you try?

When the Galo feels cared for, he gives a tiny, scratchy cluck. His voice is coming back, slowly. "Find the cup," he whispers, "and I will crow the truth."

Stop 2 The Barcelos Market

You go down to the market stalls. On one stall is an empty cushion, where the silver cup used to sit. There are no muddy footprints, no broken locks. Nobody came in or out.

You look around for clues. High above, something glints near the old bell tower. A few shiny ribbons and buttons are missing from the stalls too.



If no person took the cup, who might have? What likes shiny things and can reach a high place? Where does the glinting lead?

When you follow the clues, they all point up, up to the top of the old bell tower. Off you go.

Stop 3 The Old Bell Tower

You climb the bell tower stairs and come out at the top, among the bells. There, in a nest of buttons and ribbons, sits a little jackdaw with a grey cap. Tucked in her nest, shining, is the silver cup.

She is not a thief. She just loves shiny things, and she is shy. She tilts her head at you, holding the cup close.



How do you make friends with the shy jackdaw? Could you offer her something else that shines, or speak softly so she is not scared? What might she like?

When you are gentle and offer a fair trade, the jackdaw hops aside and lets you lift the silver cup from her nest. She even chirps a thank-you.

Stop 4 The Cup Returned

You carry the silver cup back down to the market. You hold it up high for everyone to see. "Here it is," you say. "Nobody stole it. A little jackdaw borrowed it for her nest."

The townsfolk go quiet. They look at the tired traveller they had blamed. They feel sorry for being unfair to a stranger.



How do you help the townsfolk be kind to the traveller again? What could you say so everyone feels better?

When the traveller is welcomed and given some bread and a smile, the whole square warms up. Now there is only one thing left to do.

The Dawn Crow

You set the silver cup back on its cushion. The Galo de Barcelos puffs up his chest. He opens his beak and, this time, out comes a big, bright crow that rings across the rooftops.

The sun leaps up, golden and warm. The market wakes, the stalls open, and the traveller waves goodbye with a happy heart. The Galo only ever crows the truth, and today the truth was kind.

You did it together. You were kind, and you were full of ideas. Well done.

The Galo's Silent Dawn: Rules for the Grown-Up

The Guide for the Grown-Up explains how the game works (the difficulty bands, the energy stars, helping, twists, all of it). This page has only what is special about this adventure. A failed roll is never a defeat; nobody loses.

Setting up

- Print the map, or sketch it, or lay it out with household objects: a Start, four stops, and a Goal on a winding path. Each player puts a small figure on the Start.
- Each player chooses one or two magics from the five in this world: Bloom, Truth, Starlight, Riversong, or Birdsong. A mix across the players works best.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). These are spent and refilled during play.
- Build the things that come up (the silver cup, the jackdaw's shiny nest) from household bits and bricks as you go. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

The surprise

Once at each stop the players may roll for a twist; read the matching line. The Guide explains how it works.

Roll	Surprise
1	A market seller offers you a warm pastel and one free hint.
2	You find a dropped coin that glints: take back one energy star.
3	A cool breeze off the river: the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Galo gives an encouraging cluck. All is well; carry on.
5	A passing pilgrim lets you repeat one roll later, whenever you like.
6	A church bell rings the hour and everyone feels brave for one turn.

How it ends

There is no thief in this story and no villain. The "crime" is an innocent mix-up: a shy jackdaw who gathered the shiny cup for her nest, not knowing the trouble it caused. The heart of the adventure is clearing a wrongly blamed stranger and being gentle with the timid jackdaw, so the Galo de Barcelos can crow the truth at dawn. Let the moment when the townsfolk realise their unfairness land softly; the lesson is to be fair and kind, especially to a stranger. See the puzzles page for how to play each stop, and for the solutions.

The Galo's Silent Dawn: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward good ideas and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Silent Roost (Easy)

The challenge. The Galo de Barcelos has lost his crow and his spirits. He will not find his voice until the players cheer and care for him.

Intended solutions. A gentle-heart moment more than a magic trick:

- **Riversong** to fetch him a sip of cool spring water and ask the water to soothe his throat.
- **Bloom** to bring a little colour and life back to his drooping perch.
- **Birdsong** to call to him as one bird to another and coax his own song back out.
- A plain kind act with no magic: sitting with him, singing softly, or promising out loud to clear the traveller's name.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, have the Galo manage a single weak cluck in answer to any kindness, showing them it is working. Any genuine care brings his voice partway back and tops up an energy star.

Make it simpler. For a younger child, just stroke the rooster's feathers or say one kind thing, and let that be enough for him to whisper the next clue.

Stop 2: The Barcelos Market (Normal)

The challenge. The silver cup is gone with no thief in sight: no footprints, no broken lock. The players must work out that no person took it, and follow the trail of small shiny thefts (a ribbon, a button, a glint by the tower) upward to the bell tower.

Solution. The clues add up to a creature that loves shiny things and can reach high places, and the glints lead to the top of the **old bell tower**. This is observation and logic, not a magic, though **Starlight** can make a faint glint easier to spot, **Riversong** can ask the square what it saw, and **Birdsong** can ask the market birds which way the shiny little thief flew.

Fallback. If the children are stuck, have a market seller mention "that cheeky bird up the tower has had my buttons again," handing them the link. Reaching the answer with a nudge still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Make it simpler. For a younger child, lay out three shiny clue objects leading in a line toward a tall "tower" (a stack of cups) and ask only "where do the shiny things lead?"

Stop 3: The Old Bell Tower (Normal)

The challenge. The shy jackdaw has the cup in her nest. She loves shiny things and is easily startled. The players must befriend her, not snatch the cup.

Intended solutions. A befriending moment:

- **A fair shiny swap.** Offer her something that shines just as much (a carried trinket, a polished button) to take the cup's place in her nest.
- **A gentle voice.** Speak softly and move slowly so she is not frightened, and she will let you take it.
- **Starlight** to conjure a glint she finds even more delightful, or **Truth** to show her gently that the cup is needed and a swap is fair.
- **Birdsong** to speak to her in her own jackdaw chatter, so she stays calm and comes out instead of taking fright.

Fallback. If the children freeze, have the jackdaw herself nudge a shiny button toward them, as if proposing the trade. The instant they offer any kindness or swap, let her hop aside and release the cup.

Make it simpler. For a younger child, a single shiny swap is plenty; the jackdaw is timid but easily pleased.

Stop 4: The Cup Returned (Easy)

The challenge. The players return the cup and, harder, help the townsfolk undo their unfairness and welcome the wrongly blamed traveller.

Intended solution. Have the players show the cup and explain there was no thief, then say something that turns the crowd's shame into kindness: an invitation, a shared loaf, a warm welcome for the traveller. There is no roll to fail. **Truth** fits naturally here, but plain kind words work.

Fallback. If a child is unsure what to say, have the traveller smile and offer forgiveness first, making it easy for the townsfolk to follow. The success is guaranteed; this stop is about the warm feeling of fairness restored.

Make it simpler. For a younger child, simply handing the traveller a piece of bread and saying sorry together is the whole of it.

The Dawn Crow (no roll)

This is the resolution, not a puzzle, so there is no band and no roll. The cup goes back on its cushion, the Galo de Barcelos crows at last, and the sun rises over Barcelos. Let the children feel the market wake and the traveller leave happy. They won by being gentle with the jackdaw and fair to a stranger, which is the only way anyone wins among the Enchanted Springs.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.